The BJP, the evidence clearly shows, is no longer a party of ‘savarns’. At least in UP. ‘What Modi has done with caste on the ground has broken new ground,’ concludes Brijesh Shukla. ‘Rahul Gandhi and others are not understanding this. They think they can win on Twitter. Actually, BJP was playing a very long-term game thinking of the long-term with caste. How will its opponents fight it if they don’t understand this?’[58]

How the BSP Became a Party of the Rich: A Question of Money

In politics, a party does not have to be perfect on a particular metric. It only has to be better than its opponents. We have already seen how the BJP compared with SP on OBC mobilisation. What worked in its favour was also the fact that its other opponent, BSP, while remaining a party of Dalits, had also become a party of the rich by 2019. Originally set up by Kanshi Ram as part of the great Dalit political revolution, under Mayawati, the party began to change character.

Consider this: in UP in 2004, the BSP had only 1.3 per cent candidates who had assets greater than ₹5 crore. That percentage quadrupled by the next election to 21.5 per cent in 2009, then doubled to 45 per cent in 2014 and went up as high as 67.57 per cent by 2019 (see Figure 3.7). The BSP may have retained its Dalit vote base, but it was predominantly fielding only rich candidates in the elections. This change happened after Mayawati won power with the party’s first full majority mandate in UP politics in 2007. One reason for so many rich candidates may have been that, after 2007, the BSP allegedly started selling its party tickets to the highest bidder—an allegation that many have made in the past. While I could not verify this independently, the data shows that the BSP started fielding a disproportionately high number of rich candidates.

When we started enquiring about their backgrounds during the research for the Mehta–Singh Social Index, we found that many BSP candidates were the hardest to get a fix on. Often, even the district presidents of the party did not know who a particular candidate was. This meant that, in many cases, they had no political reputation at all